

SUPINE LEG STRETCH

Supta Padangusthasana

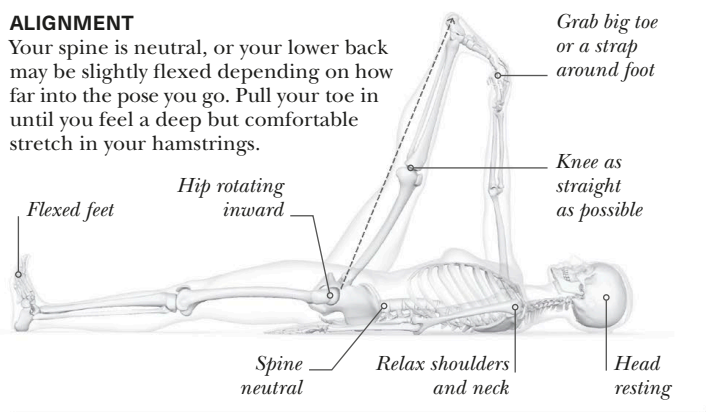
This pose and its variations stretch your thighs in a way that is particularly safe for your lower back. This can be very relaxing and great for winding down after a long day. If you are unable to grasp your toes, try holding onto a strap around the bottom of your foot.

THE BIG PICTURE

The back of your lifted thigh and leg intensely stretch. Your arms gently pull your leg in, but you should try to relax any muscles that are not necessary for this action (like your jaw, neck, and shoulders).

ALIGNMENT

Your spine is neutral, or your lower back may be slightly flexed depending on how far into the pose you go. Pull your toe in until you feel a deep but comfortable stretch in your hamstrings.



Lifted thigh and lower leg
Your **hip flexors** engage while your **quadriceps** extend your knee. Your **hip extensors**—particularly your **hamstrings** and **gluteus maximus**—stretch. As you grasp at your toes you'll likely feel your **ankle plantar flexors**—especially your **calf muscles**—stretching.

Lowered thigh and lower leg

In this version of the pose, your lowered thigh and leg are slightly engaged to stabilize.

Your **hip flexors** are in a slightly lengthened position, your **quadriceps** extend your knees, and your **hamstrings** are slightly engaging. Your **ankle dorsiflexors** engage while your **plantar flexors** are in a neutral or lengthening position.

Rectus femoris
Vastus lateralis
Iliotibial band
Biceps femoris (long head)
Biceps femoris (short head)
Knee
Gastrocnemius
Extensor digitorum longus
Tibialis anterior

